

We must ensure a 'maximum' does minimum damage

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One of sport's mysteries is how such few people in the stands actually get hit by the ball. Even in the IPL, where a six is hit with astonishing frequency, many of these into the crowd, I can remember very few cases besides the one which struck a spectator in Mullanpur this season.

More than a decade back, one of Chris Gayle's sixes hit a young girl who was then visited by the batter and told he should keep up the good work (of hitting sixes, not spectators). On another occasion, a policeman came in the way of a six.

In four decades of reporting on the game, the closest a six came to me in the Press Box (as the open-air media boxes were known then) was hit by Hansie Cronje in Sharjah. The ball fell on the table in front and was quickly defused before it could do any harm.

I once saw a player throw the ball into the crowd after taking a catch. It was flat and dangerous, and narrowly missed a lady with a child in her arms. The lucky baby would be in his late 30s now, and I wonder if that throw is part of his family lore.

There's usually someone with the reflexes, the presence of mind or the luck to ensure that a 'maximum', does minimum damage.

Stadiums are designed with clear separation in mind. The field is theatre, the stands seat the audience. Between them lie ropes, fences, advertising boards. But sport, in its more exuberant moods, resists such neat



compartmentalisation. **A cricket ball struck with sufficient ambition does not recognise these divisions. It has only one master — the laws of physics.**

There is often a brief warning. A rising murmur, a collective intake of breath, the shout of 'catch!' Heads tilt upward, hands are half-raised in optimism or self-defence. And then comes impact, or relief, or both.

The reactions are telling. There are those who carry a broken tooth or a bruised elbow as a badge of honour, souvenirs more authentic than anything sold at the merchandise stall. They will recount, with embellishment, how they "almost

caught it." Sporting memory, like sport itself, is generous to those who participate.

Others complain they did not come to be part of the action. They came to watch, to relax with friends and debate selections. For them, the intrusion is unjust.

The ball does not discriminate. It does not know ticket prices or seating tiers. It travels where it is sent, obeying only the fleeting genius (or miscalculation) of the batter. If it lands in your lap, or on your elbow, you have been, however briefly, drawn into the game's inner circle.

There is too the possibility (actually, certainty) of being on national television for the 15 seconds of fame that is guaranteed everybody in his lifetime. And the assurance of being evoked in family discussions for a couple of generations. A broken tooth or a bruised elbow is small price to pay.